

▼ JUSTINIAN I

Also known as Justinian the Great, this emperor ruled from 527–565 CE while the Byzantine Empire was at the height of its power. He reformed Roman law into the Corpus Juris Civilis, which still forms the basis of some legal systems today. He also ordered the construction of the Hagia Sophia church.

The halo represents the religious authority of the emperor over the Church.

The Byzantine Empire

In 395 CE, the Roman Empire was split into the Western and Eastern empires for the final time. While the Western Roman Empire fell to the Germanic tribes by 476 CE, the Eastern Empire, which came to be known as the Byzantine Empire, thrived and outlasted its western counterpart by almost a thousand years.

The Byzantine Empire was ruled from Constantinople (modern-day Istanbul), which had become the capital of the Eastern Roman Empire c. 324 CE. The city soon became one of the largest and richest in all of Europe, a position it held until the early 13th century.

During its thousand-year existence, the Byzantine Empire developed sophisticated legal systems. It also created its own version of Christianity called Eastern Orthodoxy, which had a strong influence on Byzantine art and architecture. Almost all forms of art produced during this time expressed religious ideas and themes.

The empire began to decline from the 11th century onward, although it held on for another 400 years, before falling to the Ottoman Turks (see pp.100–101) who captured Constantinople in 1453.

Tyrian purple robes were a symbol of royalty.

